Nagaland. He pointed out that Tawang was vital ground and its fall into Chinese hands would have far more disastrous consequences than the fall of Dhola. Umrao Singh's cautionary note did not go down well with the Eastern Army Commander, Lieutenant General L. P. Bogey Sen, who until then, had hardly shown any interest in the affairs of NEFA.

Niranjan Prasad reverted to Dalvi with the following directions: 7 Infantry Brigade should be prepared to move to the Dhola area in the next 48 hours (12-13 September) as desired by Eastern Command; 1 Sikh was to remain in Tawang guarding the Bum-la axis; 9 Punjab was to move immediately to Lumpu. He further directed that in the event of a confrontation with the Chinese, the Indians should do the following: First, persuade them to vacate Indian territory; second, if persuasion was not effective then dig in to prevent them from advancing any further and; third, firing to be resorted to only in self-defence. The brigade commander, Dalvi, was to stay in Tawang till 9 Punjab reached Lumpu en route to Dhola.

Sen and Umrao Singh visited Niranjan Prasad at Tezpur two days later. Despite Umrao Singh's clear-headed views, Sen expressed his deep dissatisfaction with the pace at which things were moving. A harried Niranjan Prasad then got on the phone to Tawang and yelled at Dalvi to get a move on, ordering the bewildered brigade commander to move immediately to Lumpu. Niranjan Prasad shouting at Dalvi on the phone was totally out of character. Obviously, GOC 4 Division could see a situation developing which he knew was far from practical, yet he seemed incapable of putting his foot down. 9 Punjab's orders were also changed, asking them to concentrate on Dhola rather than Lumpu. Moving with his Brigade HQ, Dalvi reached Lumpu on 16 October.

The bulk of 2 Rajput also reached Tawang on the same evening. The battalion had, as yet, received no orders. From Charduar, the battalion had made its way to Tenga and then journeyed onto Dirang Dzong via Bomdila. It was then split into two groups—the first group consisting of Alpha, Bravo and Charlie Companies left Dirang Dzong for Senge at 8 a.m. on 12 September under Rikh, while the second, consisting of Delta, Support and Administrative Companies under Major Pant were to follow a day later. The heavier part of the unit baggage had to be left behind at Dirang Dzong under the care of the unit pandit. Lieutenant Colonel Rikh's group reached Senge, just below Se-la Top, at 4 p.m. on 12 September. All vehicles had to